50TH ANNIVERSARY

SPORTS
2015-2025



NIKHAT ZAREEN
Two-time boxing world champion, at a media interaction in 2024

"*Kabhi socha nahin tha ek ladki* [I had never imagined that a girl] who was once a challenger would become the face of Indian boxing.... I feel blessed and grateful"

Photograph by **BANDEEP SINGH**



Women Power
Aug. 16, 2021

"P.V. Sindhu had just won her second Olympic medal and the few of us from India who were in the stands were understandably ecstatic. After all, Olympic medals are still hard to come by for India, and Sindhu is the happy exception.... The diminutive weightlifter Mirabai Chanu once lifted logs to ensure they could light a winter fire in their home before she went on to win a silver at Tokyo. There was no permanent road to Lovlina Borgohain's home, but that didn't stop her from boxing her way to a bronze."

the sport was convulsed by a bitter sexual harassment scandal at home. In the ring, Lovlina Borgohain and Nikhat Zareen carried Indian boxing into a golden, global light. Mirabai Chanu lifted more than weights, hauling an entire sport back into national consciousness, while in shooting, Manu Bhaker's calm under pressure delivered twin Olympic bronzes in Paris 2024.

But it was a javelin arcing into the Tokyo sky that split history. Neeraj Chopra delivered India's first Olympic athletics gold in 2021, then returned with silver from Paris and a World Championship crown too. And after decades of longing, the men's hockey team captured back-to-back Olympic bronzes in 2021 and 2024—a revival soaked in sweat and self-belief.

On the quiet, cerebral edge of Indian sport, a generation of teen Grandmasters led by Gukesh Dommaraju—who in 2024 became the youngest world champion at 18—began rearranging global chess hierarchies. As 2025 neared its close, India's ambition to host the 2036 Olympics found new wind with the 2030 Commonwealth Games rights, signalling a country ready to build grand arenas worthy of its champions. ■